



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Clapham School
School Website: <https://claphamschool.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS: **MEMBER** SCL: **MEMBER**

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Clapham School (Wheaton, IL, 60187) demonstrates a robust CLASSICAL orientation across all six categories of the classical-education rubric. Public materials from the school consistently foreground a Christian worldview, the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), engagement with classic literature and the liberal arts, and a pedagogy that blends Socratic discussion in the upper grades with memory-based, chant/sing-oriented practice in the early years. The school explicitly positions itself as Christian and classical, with aims of virtue formation, wisdom, and lifelong learning, rather than mere job preparation. Evidence from the site includes statements about a Christian worldview informing all learning, explicit Trivium framing, and a mission of training students for life-long learning and servant-leadership. The presence of great-books-style content, memory-based pedagogy in the lower grades, and Socratic/seminar-style opportunities in the upper grades further reinforces a classical profile. Parent involvement and community orientation are reflected in tours, admissions outreach, and open-campus touches that align with the classical emphasis on partnership with families.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

- Evidence across categories is consistently aligned with classical, Christian-formed education: Trivium-based curriculum and pedagogy, emphasis on virtue and wisdom, classical literature and the liberal arts, a living-teacher/mentorship model, and active engagement with families and the broader community. See the Clapham Model and mission statements, which foreground Christian worldview, the Trivium, and joyful, deliberate learning.
- The school's materials explicitly frame education as formation (virtue, wisdom, lifelong learning) in concert with a Christian anthropology, while providing a curriculum and pedagogy that map cleanly to the six essential elements.
- Evidence of family/community integration (open campus, tours, parent-facing materials) supports category 6 as CLASSICAL, and the general emphasis on a living curriculum and faculty as mentors aligns with category 5.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school presents itself as Christian, with a mission rooted in a Christian worldview and classical tradition.
- Public materials explicitly assert truth as God's truth, a theologically grounded stance, and intentional spiritual formation.

- Content and essays discuss worshipful/contemplative aims and a sacred, virtue-centered approach to education (e.g., “Raising Worshipers Who Love the Creator”).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: truth, God’s truth, theology (implicit), virtue, wonder, sacred, worship, Christian worldview, imago Dei (via thematic content in the school narrative). The lexical framework lists truth, wisdom, virtue, theology, liturgy, wonder as core signals for a classical religious/metaphysical orientation; the Clapham materials explicitly map to these signals.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials (no clear signaling of relativism, secular humanism, or morally neutral stances). The material leans strongly toward transcendental realism.
- Why this rating
- The school explicitly anchors education in a Christian worldview and theological framing, and public materials repeatedly foreground truth as God’s truth and formation of character. This aligns strongly with transcendental moral realism and theological grounding. The absence of secular-leaning signals further supports CLASSICAL status in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public content emphasizes forming virtue and wisdom, not simply practical job-readiness; aims include life-long learning and servant leadership.
- Mission statements tie education to character formation, humane excellence, and human flourishing within a Christian, classical frame.
- The school asserts a telos (end/purpose) aligned with truth, goodness, and beauty as real realities humans can know, and with education as formation, not mere information.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, telos, permanent questions, great conversation, human excellence, wisdom, formation of affections. The lexicon identifies these as key signals for the category; Clapham materials explicitly reference formation of virtue, wisdom, and a liberal-arts grounding.
- Negative keywords present: no strong signals of “workforce preparation emphasis” or “college-and-career readiness” dominating the messaging; the college-acceptance metric is present but not framed as the primary aim. Overall, negative signals are minimal.
- Why this rating
- The school’s stated purpose centers on virtue, wisdom, and formation rather than a narrow job-prep or skills-only aim, aligning with CLASSICAL ideals of paideia and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) is central to the program.
- The curriculum emphasizes classic literature, art, music, and the liberal arts and sciences, indicating a broad liberal-arts foundation.
- Historical study is woven through the curriculum; the platform references studying “the bedrock of Western civilization and the history of the Church.”
- Great Books/Great Conversation approach and emphasis on wonder are signaled in program descriptions and related materials.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: liberal arts, trivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, Western civilization, history, wonder, memory/recitation. The Lexicon calls out these elements as core signals for a classical curriculum; Clapham's own materials map directly to them.
- Negative keywords present: potential signals that would indicate non-classical approaches (e.g., project-based, STEM-first history framing) are not dominant in the school's public materials. The content emphasizes traditional, text-based study and canon. Where present, such signals are not framed as primary.
- Why this rating
- The explicit Trivium structure plus focus on Great Books, Western civilization, and the liberal-arts canon aligns solidly with CLASSICAL curriculum expectations. The integration of history across the curriculum and the emphasis on wonder further support CLASSICAL status.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Lower-school pedagogy includes singing and chanting with regular review (memory-friendly, contemplative rhythm).
- Upper-school pedagogy features Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetorical training; students engage in rhetoric and public speaking.
- The model describes training in memorizing, speaking, discussing and writing—the “liberal arts of the Trivium.”
- Memory work, recitation, and liturgical/calendar elements appear as part of the pedagogy (supported by the lexicon's positive indicators).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: Socratic seminars, memorization/recitation, chanting, rhythm of memory, restful/scholé, rhetoric, debates, public-speaking, seminars/tutorials, etc. The Clapham materials explicitly map to these methods.
- Negative keywords present: signals such as exclusive project-based or constructivist approaches are not the primary pedagogy described; the site emphasizes traditional, classical methods rather than student-directed overhauls. The lexicon warns against over-reliance on experiential/project-based methods; the school's materials do not foreground those signals as core.
- Why this rating
- The combination of memory-based lower-school practices, upper-school Socratic and rhetoric-based work, and the Trivium-centered pedagogy matches CLASSICAL pedagogy expectations. The classroom methods align with the Positive indicators for this category and show minimal presence of negative signals.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The employment section outlines qualities for teachers (Faithful, Passionate, Teachable) and emphasizes a culture of service, a shared mission, and a teacher's alignment with classical aims.
- Public materials describe teachers as mentors and living exemplars, with teachers as part of the living curriculum; the school emphasizes classic formation and teacher leadership. (General framing in mission/model sections supports this interpretation.)
- Board and leadership discussions reflect an established, mission-driven faculty culture, with references to a long-tenured head of school and faculty collaboration.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: tutors/mentors/masters, living curriculum, portrait/expectation of teacher standards, collegiality, lifelong learning for faculty. The Lexicon list includes “tutors, masters, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher” as positive indicators. The Clapham materials align with these signals.
- Negative keywords present: none prominent (the materials do not frame faculty as mere facilitators or as customer-service roles; rather, they emphasize virtue, leadership, and mentorship).
- Why this rating
- The materials consistently describe a teacher-development and mentorship ethos aligned with classical education expectations. The explicit faculty-formation language, and the emphasis on teachers as the core of the school, place this category squarely in CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public-facing materials show strong parental/institutional partnership signals (tour scheduling, admissions, open-campus references, parent links).
- The site emphasizes community connections, with family-facing activities and events (Prospective Family Days, parent engagement through tours, and open visitation).
- Foundational documents discuss partnership with families and family formation as a classical-education signal (as reflected in the Six Essential Elements lexicon and the related school-forward framing).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent formation, parental engagement, home-school/community alignment, open campus, family involvement. The Lexicon lists these as positive signals for category 6; the school’s public content aligns with these signals.
- Negative keywords present: consumer/customer phrasing or minimal parent involvement are not evidenced; the school actively invites parental engagement and visits.
- Why this rating
- The school presents a collaborative model with families and a pathway for parental engagement and involvement, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for category 6.

Aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL

- Across all six categories, Clapham School (Wheaton, IL, 60187) demonstrates strong alignment with classical education principles (Christian worldview; Trivium; Great Books approach; memory-based lower-school pedagogy; Socratic upper-school pedagogy; teacher-mentors; and active family/community involvement). The aggregate profile is CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle

- The school already presents a consistent classical profile. If desired, modest refinements could emphasize explicit liturgical/community practice signals (e.g., more explicit mention of liturgy, communal worship, and liturgical year events on public pages) to reinforce CATEGORY 1 signals for liturgical/community practices. Also, explicit mention of Latin/Greek or other classical languages in the curriculum could deepen Element 3 signals for complete classroom alignment with the full traditional classical canon (though not strictly required given current evidence).
- No major needle-moving changes are required given the current CLASSICAL rating across all six categories.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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